

Ancient History — Iranian & Macedonian Invasions

Chapter 16 | Sources: RS Sharma (Ancient Past) + Upinder Singh (Ancient & Early Medieval India)

GS Paper I — History | Art & Culture

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Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH

Iranian (Achaemenid) Invasions of India

GS-I History

■ NEWS TRIGGER

India-Iran Chabahar Port deal (2024-25) revives the ancient Sindhu-Persia corridor — the same NW India route used by Darius I is now India's strategic gateway to Central Asia and Afghanistan.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The Achaemenid Persian Empire, founded by Cyrus the Great (~550 BCE), was the first foreign power to formally annex parts of northwestern India. Darius I (522-486 BCE) incorporated the Sindhu region as the 20th satrapy of his empire (which had 28 satrapies in total), making it the most lucrative province — paying 360 talents of gold dust annually, more than all other provinces combined.

RS Sharma states: 'Darius annexed Punjab, west of the Indus, and Sindh. This area was converted into the twentieth province or satrapy of Iran, which had a total number of twenty-eight satrapies. The Indian satrapy included Sindh, the north-west frontier, and the part of Punjab that lay to the west of the Indus. It paid a tribute of 360 talents of gold, which accounted for one-third of the total revenue Iran received from its Asian provinces.' Entry was always via the Khyber Pass into Gandhara, then the Sindhu plains.

■ TIMELINE

550 BCE — Cyrus the Great founds Achaemenid Empire; reaches Gandhara region — no formal annexation of India

522 BCE — Darius I ascends throne; commissions Bisitun/Behistun Inscription (trilingual: Old Persian, Elamite, Babylonian) — first epigraphic mention of India as 'Hi(n)du'

516 BCE — RS Sharma: Darius formally annexes Punjab and Sindh as 20th satrapy of Persian Empire

518 BCE — Darius sends Scylax (Greek explorer) to survey the Indus river

490 BCE — Battle of Marathon — Indian soldiers fight for Persia (Darius I) against Greece

486 BCE — Xerxes I succeeds Darius; maintains hold on Gandhara and Hidu provinces

480 BCE — Battle of Thermopylae — Indian soldiers in Xerxes I's army (RS Sharma confirmed)

479 BCE — Battle of Plataea — Indian troops still part of Xerxes' Greek campaign

404-359 BCE — Upinder Singh: Indians still mentioned as subjects under Artaxerxes II

336-330 BCE — Darius III's army includes Indian troops (mercenaries per Upinder Singh); Alexander defeats Darius III — Persian Empire ends

■ KEY DATA

King	Period	India Connection	Key Fact
Cyrus the Great	550-530 BCE	Reached Gandhara; no formal annexation	Founded Achaemenid Empire
Darius I	522-486 BCE	Annexed Sindhu (20th of 28 satrapies); Bisitun Inscription; sent Scylax	MOST IMPORTANT for India — RS Sharma

King	Period	India Connection	Key Fact
Xerxes I	486-465 BCE	Indian troops at Thermopylae & Plataea — RS Sharma confirmed	Invaded Greece
Artaxerxes II	404-359 BCE	Indians still Persian subjects — Upinder Singh	Long Persian control
Darius III	336-330 BCE	Indian mercenaries in army — Upinder Singh	Last Achaemenid king

■ STATIC THEORY

- **SATRAPY:** Provincial unit of Persian Empire. RS Sharma: total 28 satrapies; India = 20th. Governed by a Satrap with civil + tax + military powers. Influenced later Mauryan provincial administration
- **TALENT:** Ancient weight-based currency (~26 kg metal). 360 gold talents = India's tribute = one-third of total Asian revenue (RS Sharma) = more than all other provinces combined (Upinder Singh)
- **BISITUN INSCRIPTION:** Commissioned by Darius I (~520 BCE); trilingual (Old Persian + Elamite + Babylonian); located in modern Iran (Kermanshah); first epigraphic mention of India as 'Hi(n)du' province
- **KHAROSHTHI SCRIPT:** Iranian cultural legacy; written right to left (unlike Brahmi); used in NW India for centuries — entered India through Persian administrative contact
- **PERSIAN COINS IN INDIA:** Daric and Sigloi coins (Upinder Singh) found in Tchaman-i-Hazouri hoard near Kabul and Bhir mound — material evidence of Persian presence
- **BELL-SHAPED PILLAR CAPITALS:** Ashoka's pillars derived from Achaemenid/Persepolis architectural style — Iranian legacy, NOT Greek
- **INDIAN SOLDIERS IN PERSIAN WARS:** RS Sharma: 'The Indian subjects were also enrolled in the Iranian army. Xerxes employed Indians in the long war against the Greeks.' — fought at Marathon, Thermopylae, AND Plataea

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Total Persian satrapies = 28 (NOT 20) — India was 20th of 28 (RS Sharma)
2. 360 gold talents = one-third of all Asian revenue; highest tribute (RS Sharma + Upinder Singh)
3. Darius I formally annexed: Punjab (west of Indus) + Sindh + NW Frontier — NOT all of NW India
4. Bisitun/Behistun Inscription = Darius I; trilingual; in modern Iran (not India)
5. Scylax = Greek explorer sent by Darius I to survey Indus
6. Kharoshthi = right to left; Iranian legacy; used in NW India
7. Indian soldiers at ALL THREE battles: Marathon (490), Thermopylae (480), Plataea (479)
8. Daric and Sigloi = Persian coins found in NW India (Upinder Singh)
9. Persian occupation: 516-330 BCE (~186 years) until Alexander destroyed empire

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Persian Empire had 20 satrapies total
- ✓ Total satrapies = 28; India was the 20th (RS Sharma)
- ✗ Kharoshthi was brought by Alexander (Greek)
- ✓ Kharoshthi is an IRANIAN legacy — predates Alexander by ~200 years
- ✗ Bell-shaped pillar capitals = Greek influence
- ✓ Bell-shaped capitals = PERSIAN (Achaemenid); Greek = Gandhara art (centuries later)
- ✗ Indian soldiers fought at Marathon + Thermopylae only
- ✓ Indians fought at ALL THREE: Marathon, Thermopylae, AND Plataea (RS Sharma + Upinder Singh)
- ✗ Bisitun Inscription is in Indian script

✓ Trilingual in Old Persian, Elamite, Babylonian — NO Indian script; located in modern Iran

■ MAINS ANGLE

Analyse how Persian administrative models (satrapy system, tribute collection, provincial governance) influenced the structure of the Mauryan Empire — with reference to RS Sharma's argument on administrative continuity.

■ STUDY LINK

History → Ancient India → Chapter 17 (Mauryan Empire) — satrapy-to-province administrative continuity | Art & Culture → Pillar Architecture → Persian influence

HIGH

Alexander's Macedonian Invasion (327-325 BCE)

GS-I History

■ NEWS TRIGGER

PM Modi's Greece visit (2023) — first Indian PM in 40 years — invoked Alexander-India historical connection; India-Greece strategic partnership elevated. Also: Gandharan Buddhist heritage preservation discussions at UNESCO 2025.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Alexander III of Macedon entered India via Khyber Pass in 327 BCE, after conquering Persia. RS Sharma's chronology: Alexander invaded India in 326 BCE and remained for nineteen months (326-325 BCE). His campaign touched only NW India — he never crossed the Beas river eastward. Upinder Singh notes: 'Alexander's invasion is generally seen as having briefly grazed the north-western rim of the subcontinent, not leading to any major or long-term impact.'

Alexander's eastward drive was motivated by desire for glory, curiosity about the 'ends of the earth', and knowledge of India's wealth from Persian records. He crossed the Indus in 326 BCE. Ambhi of Taxila surrendered (using Alexander against rival Porus). Porus fought at the Battle of Hydaspes (Jhelum) — lost but was restored. Army mutinied at the Beas. Alexander left India in 325 BCE and died at Babylon in 323 BCE, age 32.

■ TIMELINE

330 BCE — Alexander defeats Darius III; destroys Persepolis; Persian Empire ends — paves way for India entry

327 BCE — Alexander enters India via Khyber Pass; subdues Gandhara region

326 BCE — RS Sharma: 'Alexander invaded India' — army crosses Indus; Ambhi of Taxila surrenders (Upinder Singh)

326 BCE (May) — Battle of Hydaspes (River Jhelum) — Porus 'offered resistance, but was overpowered' (Upinder Singh); kingdom RESTORED — 'treat me as a king treats a king'

326 BCE (Nov) — Army mutiny at River Beas (Hyphasis) — RS Sharma: 'war-weary, diseased, homesick after ten years of continuous campaigning'

325 BCE — Alexander leaves India; Nearchus commands fleet down Indus to Persian Gulf; RS Sharma: total stay = 19 months

323 BCE — Alexander dies at Babylon, age 32

322 BCE — Chandragupta Maurya founds Mauryan Empire — RS Sharma: 'had seen something of the working of Alexander's military machine... helped him to destroy the power of the Nandas'

305 BCE — Chandragupta defeats Seleucus Nicator; NW territories ceded; Megasthenes sent as Greek ambassador to Pataliputra

■ KEY DATA

Greek River Name	Indian River	Event
Indus	Sindhu/Indus	Alexander's army crossed in 326 BCE (Upinder Singh)
Hydaspes	Jhelum	Battle of Hydaspes — Alexander vs Porus
Acesines	Chenab	Porus ruled area between Jhelum and Chenab (Upinder Singh)
Hydraotes	Ravi	Alexander captured area between Chenab and Ravi (Upinder Singh)
Hyphasis	Beas	EASTERNMOST point — army mutiny; Alexander turned back

■ STATIC THEORY

- **BATTLE OF HYDASPES (326 BCE):** RS Sharma: 'Alexander defeated Porus, he was impressed by the bravery and courage of the Indian prince. He therefore restored his kingdom to him and made him his ally.' Upinder Singh: 'Porus (Puru or Paurava) ruled the area between the Jhelum and Chenab'
- **ARMY MUTINY AT BEAS:** RS Sharma: 'The Greek soldiers had grown war-weary, and diseased. The hot climate of India and ten years of continuous campaigning had made them terribly homesick.' Coenus was the general who spoke for the army
- **CHANDRAGUPTA-ALEXANDER LINK:** RS Sharma directly states Chandragupta 'had seen something of the working of Alexander's military machine and had acquired some knowledge that helped him to destroy the power of the Nandas' — direct causal link
- **HISTORIOGRAPHICAL CAUTION (Upinder Singh):** 'Alexander's invasion is generally seen as having briefly grazed the north-western rim of the subcontinent, not leading to any major or long-term impact' — modern historians DOWNPLAY Alexander's significance for India
- **STAY IN INDIA:** RS Sharma: Alexander remained in India for NINETEEN MONTHS (326-325 BCE)
- **KEY PEOPLE:** Ambhi (Taxila) = surrendered, gave support to Greeks; Porus (Paurava) = fought, kingdom restored; Nearchus = admiral, Indus fleet; Megasthenes = Seleucus's ambassador to Chandragupta (NOT Alexander's envoy)

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Alexander crossed Indus: 326 BCE (Upinder Singh) | Stayed: 19 months (RS Sharma)
2. Ambhi (Taxila) = surrendered + supported Greeks | Porus (Paurava) = fought at Jhelum, kingdom restored
3. Porus ruled area between Jhelum AND Chenab (Upinder Singh) — not just Jhelum region
4. Army mutinied at Beas — war-weary, diseased, homesick after ten years (RS Sharma)
5. Alexander left India 325 BCE | Died Babylon 323 BCE (age 32)
6. RS Sharma: Chandragupta learned from Alexander's military machine → used to defeat Nandas
7. Upinder Singh: Alexander's invasion 'briefly grazed north-western rim... NOT major or long-term impact'

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Battle of Hydaspes was on River Indus
- ✓ Hydaspes = JHELUM; Alexander crossed Indus first, then fought Porus at Jhelum (Upinder Singh)
- ✗ Alexander reached Magadha or Pataliputra
- ✓ He NEVER crossed the Beas — never entered Gangetic plains
- ✗ Porus was executed after defeat
- ✓ RS Sharma: kingdom RESTORED; Porus made Alexander's ally
- ✗ Megasthenes was Alexander's envoy

8. Megasthenes = sent by SELEUCUS NICATOR (not Alexander) to Chandragupta's court 9. Nearchus = admiral who navigated Indus fleet to Persian Gulf	✓ Megasthenes was sent by SELEUCUS NICATOR to Chandragupta's court — after Alexander's death ✗ Alexander's invasion had major long-term impact on India ✓ Upinder Singh: 'generally seen as briefly grazing north-western rim... not leading to major or long-term impact' ✗ Hyphasis = Indus or Jhelum ✓ Hyphasis = BEAS — easternmost point of Alexander's advance
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■ MAINS ANGLE <i>Critically examine: 'Alexander's invasion mattered not for what it conquered but for what it enabled — assess with reference to Chandragupta Maurya's rise and RS Sharma's direct causal argument about military learning.</i>	■ STUDY LINK History → Ancient India → Chapter 17 (Mauryan Empire) → Chandragupta-Chanakya rise directly linked Art & Culture → Indo-Greek Coins + Gandhara Art
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HIGH

Legacy & Cultural Impact of Both Invasions

GS-I (Art & Culture + History) History

■ NEWS TRIGGER ASI-UNESCO collaboration on Gandharan Buddhist heritage preservation across Pakistan-Afghanistan (2025); India-Iran Chabahar Port = modern revival of ancient trade corridor established by Achaemenid-era India links.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN The Iranian and Macedonian invasions produced lasting cultural, artistic, administrative, and commercial legacies. Key distinction per Upinder Singh: Achaemenid period shows 'nominal control' over Indian provinces (no architectural remains found in subcontinent) — yet cultural transmission was deep. Gandhara art emerged centuries after Alexander but is rooted in Greek cultural presence established by his invasion. <i>Persian satrapy system inspired Mauryan provincial administration. Kharoshthi script (Iranian legacy) survived centuries in NW India. Hellenistic artistic tradition blended with Buddhist iconography to produce Gandhara art (1st-5th CE). RS Sharma directly connects Chandragupta's military success to knowledge gained from observing Alexander's campaign.</i>	■ TIMELINE 516-330 BCE — Persian satrapy system in NW India — model for Mauryan provincial administration ~300 BCE — Kharoshthi script in active use across NW India (Iranian cultural legacy) 305 BCE — Seleucus-Chandragupta treaty; Megasthenes writes Indica — first detailed Greek account of Indian society ~250 BCE — Ashoka's pillars: bell-shaped capitals = direct Persian (Achaemenid) architectural influence ~200 BCE-100 CE — Indo-Greek kingdoms in NW India (Menander/Milinda converted to Buddhism — Milindapanha)
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1st-5th CE — Gandhara art flourishes: Buddha with Greek facial features, wavy hair, toga-style robes — centuries after Alexander

■ KEY DATA

Legacy	Source	Manifestation in India	Book Citation
Kharoshthi script	Iranian	Right-to-left; NW India for centuries	RS Sharma + Upinder Singh
Bell-shaped pillar capitals	Iranian (Persian)	Ashoka's pillars; Persepolis style	Standard textbook
Daric & Sigloi coins	Iranian	Found in Tchaman-i-Hazouri hoard near Kabul	Upinder Singh
Satrapy system	Iranian	Inspired Mauryan provincial administration	RS Sharma
Gandhara art	Macedonian (Greek)	Buddha with Hellenistic features; 1st-5th CE	Standard textbook
Megasthenes' Indica	Macedonian	First detailed Greek account of Indian society/polity	RS Sharma + Upinder Singh
Indo-Greek kingdoms	Macedonian	Menander/Milinda converted to Buddhism (Milindapanha)	Standard textbook
Chandragupta's military model	Macedonian	RS Sharma: learned from Alexander's machine to defeat Nandas	RS Sharma direct quote

■ STATIC THEORY

- **GANDHARA ART (1st-5th CE):** Greek artistic style + Buddhist subject matter. Features: realistic facial features, wavy hair on Buddha, toga-style robes, Roman-influenced drapery + Indian spiritual themes, lotus motifs. Location: modern Pakistan/Afghanistan (ancient Gandhara). Created CENTURIES after Alexander — not during his invasion
- **INDO-GREEK KINGDOMS:** After Alexander's death, Greek generals carved out kingdoms in Bactria and NW India. Menander (Milinda) = famous Indo-Greek king who converted to Buddhism — recorded in Milindapanha (dialogues with monk Nagasena)
- **MEGASTHENES AND INDICA:** Greek ambassador sent by Seleucus Nicator to Chandragupta's Pataliputra. Wrote Indica — detailed account of Indian caste, army, agriculture, governance. Original lost; fragments survive in other Greek texts
- **UPINDER SINGH'S CAUTION:** 'The fact that architectural remains of the Achaemenid period have not been found so far in the subcontinent suggests a nominal control over the Indian provinces' — Persian control was administrative, not culturally transformative on the ground
- **RS SHARMA'S DIRECT LINK:** Chandragupta 'had seen something of the working of Alexander's military machine and had acquired some knowledge that helped him to destroy the power of the Nandas' — most important causal statement in this chapter

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Gandhara art = 1st-5th CE — centuries after Alexander (327 BCE)
2. Bell-shaped Ashokan pillar capitals = Persian influence (NOT Greek)
3. Daric + Sigloi = Persian coins found in NW India (Upinder Singh)
4. Megasthenes wrote Indica = first detailed foreign account of India

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Gandhara art was created during Alexander's time
- ✓ Gandhara art = 1st-5th century CE — 300-700 years AFTER Alexander's 326 BCE visit
- ✗ Bell-shaped pillar capitals = Greek influence
- ✓ Bell-shaped capitals = PERSIAN (Achaemenid); Greek = Gandhara art — never mix these

5. Milinda/Menander = Indo-Greek king who converted to Buddhism (Milindapanha) 6. Upinder Singh: Achaemenid control was 'nominal' — no architectural remains in subcontinent 7. RS Sharma: Chandragupta learned from Alexander's military machine — used to defeat Nandas 8. Kharoshthi = Iranian; Gandhara art = Greek; Bell capitals = Persian (three distinct legacies)	✗ Indica was written by Arrian ✓ MEGASTHENES wrote Indica; Arrian wrote Anabasis (Alexander's campaign) ✗ Milindapanha is about a Mauryan king ✓ Milindapanha = dialogues between MENANDER (Indo-Greek king) and Buddhist monk Nagasena ✗ Persian control of India was deep and transformative ✓ Upinder Singh: 'nominal control' — no Achaemenid architectural remains found in Indian subcontinent
■ MAINS ANGLE <i>The Iranian and Macedonian invasions transformed India from an isolated subcontinent into part of a connected Eurasian world — evaluate with reference to art, administration, trade, and the historiographical debate on Alexander's actual impact (RS Sharma vs Upinder Singh).</i>	■ STUDY LINK Art & Culture → Gandhara Art + Mathura Art (compare Greek vs indigenous) History → Mauryan Empire Ch17 RS Sharma pp. on administrative continuity

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI